front," he said. I was taken aback by Prof. Sponder's invitation. "You are my best student and hard work wil help you bring a great name for your teachers in future." Embarrassed by the praise but honoured by the recognition, I sat with Prof. Sponder for the photograph. "Let God be your hope, your stay, your guide and provide the lantern for your feet in your journey into the future," said the introverted genius, bidding me adieu.

From MIT, I went to Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) at Bangalore as a trainee. There I worked on engine overhauling as part of a team. Hands-on work on aircraft engine overhauling was very educative. When a principle learnt in the classroom is borne out by practical experience, it creates a strange sense of excitement—akin to unexpectedly running into an old friend among a crowd of strangers. At HAL, I worked on the overhauling of both piston and turbine engines. The hazy concepts of gas dynamics and diffusion processes in the working principle of after burning came into sharper focus in my mind. I was also trained in radial engine-cum-drum operations.

I learned how to check a crankshaft for wear and tear, and a connecting rod and crankshaft for twist. I did